

 Department of Children & Family Services <i>Building a Stronger Louisiana</i>	Division/Section	Family Support
	Chapter No./Name	4 – Economic Stability (ES)
	Part No./Name	B – Eligibility Factors
	Section No./Name	B-600-FITAP-SNAP Income
	Document No./Name	B-660-FITAP Budgeting
	Effective Date	June 1, 2019

I. STATEMENT OF POLICY

B-661-FITAP - PO DETERMINING ELIGIBILITY AND BENEFITS

TO DETERMINE THE AMOUNT OF INCOME TO BUDGET:

- EVALUATE THE HOUSEHOLD'S CIRCUMSTANCES AND INCOME WITH THE CLIENT.
- CONSIDER THE INCOME THE HOUSEHOLD HAS ALREADY RECEIVED AND/OR EXPECTS TO RECEIVE IN DETERMINING THE AMOUNT OF INCOME TO BE BUDGETED. IF THE HOUSEHOLD IS UNSURE OF THE AMOUNT OF INCOME EXPECTED, USE THE BEST ESTIMATE OF THE AMOUNT TO BE RECEIVED. DO NOT COUNT INCOME FROM A NEW SOURCE WHICH THE CLIENT IS NOT CERTAIN TO RECEIVE.
- Decide if any factors are likely to change in the current or future months.
- If changes are unlikely, CERTIFY THE HOUSEHOLD BASED ON ANTICIPATED INCOME AND CIRCUMSTANCES.
- IF CHANGES ARE LIKELY, DETERMINE HOW THE CHANGE WILL AFFECT ELIGIBILITY AND BENEFITS.

B-661-1-FITAP - PO Determining Earned Income

NOTE: THIS SECTION DOES NOT APPLY TO SELF-EMPLOYMENT OR CONTRACTUAL EMPLOYMENT. REFER TO [B-620-44-SNAP/FITAP](#) FOR SELF-EMPLOYMENT AND [B-620-10-SNAP/FITAP](#) FOR CONTRACTUAL EMPLOYMENT.

INCOME FROM EARNINGS MUST BE THE MOST CURRENT OR RECENT INFORMATION AVAILABLE. INCOME FROM THE CURRENT CALENDAR MONTH AND THE PRIOR CALENDAR MONTH ARE USED WHEN DETERMINING EARNED INCOME. USE AT LEAST TWO PAY PERIODS THAT ARE REPRESENTATIVE DURING THIS TIME PERIOD. IF MORE THAN TWO PAY PERIODS ARE PROVIDED, AND THEY ARE REPRESENTATIVE OF EARNINGS, WAGES FROM EACH PAY PERIOD PROVIDED THAT ARE WITHIN THE CURRENT CALENDAR MONTH AND THE PRIOR CALENDAR MONTH MUST BE USED IN DETERMINING INCOME.

IF EARNINGS FROM AT LEAST TWO PAY PERIODS WITHIN THE CURRENT CALENDAR MONTH AND THE PRIOR CALENDAR MONTH HAVE NOT BEEN PROVIDED WITH THE APPLICATION, SIMPLIFIED REPORT, REDETERMINATION, OR CHANGE REPORT, REQUEST VERIFICATION OF WAGES FOR THE CURRENT AND PRIOR CALENDAR MONTH.

EXCEPTION: ONLY ONE PAY PERIOD IS REQUIRED FOR INCOME WHICH IS PAID ON A MONTHLY BASIS.

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DO NOT REJECT THE APPLICATION OR CLOSE THE CASE FOR FAILURE TO PROVIDE VERIFICATION, IF VERIFICATION OF EARNINGS IS PROVIDED THAT MEETS THE REQUIREMENTS.

TO ESTIMATE EARNINGS FOR THE CURRENT AND FUTURE MONTHS, USE INCOME FROM AT LEAST TWO PAY PERIODS WHICH ARE REPRESENTATIVE OF INCOME AND AVAILABLE WITHIN THE CURRENT CALENDAR MONTH AND THE PRIOR CALENDAR MONTH FROM:

- THE DATE OF THE APPLICATION,
- THE DATE THE REDETERMINATION IS RECEIVED,

EXCEPTION: IF WAGES WERE VERIFIED THROUGH THE OFS-FA WEB SYSTEM CLEARANCE SUMMARY USING INFORMATION OBTAINED FROM THE WORK NUMBER, USE THE 'AS OF DATE' SHOWN ON THE 'VERIFICATION DETAILS' PANEL TO DETERMINE THE CURRENT CALENDAR MONTH AND THE PRIOR CALENDAR MONTH.

- THE DATE A SIMPLIFIED REPORT IS RECEIVED,

EXCEPTION: IF WAGES WERE VERIFIED THROUGH THE OFS-FA WEB SYSTEM CLEARANCE SUMMARY USING INFORMATION OBTAINED FROM THE WORK NUMBER, USE THE 'AS OF DATE' SHOWN ON THE 'VERIFICATION DETAILS' PANEL TO DETERMINE THE CURRENT CALENDAR MONTH AND THE PRIOR CALENDAR MONTH.

- THE DATE THE VERIFICATION IS REQUESTED,
- THE DATE OF THE MOST RECENT CHECK STUB, IF MORE CURRENT VERIFICATION IS PROVIDED, OR

NOTE: IF A CHECK STUB IS MORE CURRENT THAN THE DATE OF THE REQUEST FOR VERIFICATION, THE DATE ON THE NEW CHECK STUB WOULD BECOME THE CURRENT MONTH.

EXAMPLE: APPLICATION RECEIVED AUGUST 25 AND NO VERIFICATION PROVIDED. INTERVIEW CONDUCTED AUGUST 30 AND VERIFICATION OF WAGES REQUESTED SAME DAY FOR JULY AND AUGUST WAGES. CHECK STUB DATED SEPTEMBER 8 IS PROVIDED, THEREFORE, THE CURRENT MONTH BECOMES SEPTEMBER AND THE PRIOR MONTH BECOMES AUGUST. USE AUGUST AND SEPTEMBER WAGES.

- THE DATE THE CLIENT REPORTS A CHANGE.

THE WORK NUMBER MUST NOT BE QUERIED AGAIN TO OBTAIN MORE RECENT WAGE VERIFICATION SINCE IT HAS ALREADY BEEN MADE AVAILABLE USING THE OFS-FA WEB SYSTEM CLEARANCE SUMMARY. HOWEVER, IF THE APPLICANT/RECIPIENT REPORTS

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(EITHER IN WRITING USING THE REDETERMINATION APPLICATION OR THE SR OR DURING AN INTERVIEW) THAT AN INDIVIDUAL IN THE HOUSEHOLD HAS OBTAINED NEW EMPLOYMENT OR TERMINATED EMPLOYMENT, WHICH WAS NOT VERIFIED THROUGH THE OFS-FA WEB SYSTEM CLEARANCE SUMMARY, THE WORK NUMBER MAY BE QUERIED TO OBTAIN WAGE VERIFICATION FOR THE NEWLY REPORTED EMPLOYMENT OR TERMINATED INCOME AND TERMINATION OF EMPLOYMENT DATE FOR TERMINATED EMPLOYMENT.

THESE INSTRUCTIONS APPLY TO FLUCTUATING AND STABLE INCOME.

B-661-2-FITAP - PO Determining Unearned Income

IF UNEARNED INCOME DOES NOT FLUCTUATE, VERIFY AND BUDGET THE MONTHLY AMOUNT.

CONTINUE MONTHLY BUDGETING OF PAYMENTS SUCH AS FITAP, SSI AND SOCIAL SECURITY EVEN THOUGH MAILING CYCLES MAY CAUSE TWO PAYMENTS TO BE RECEIVED IN ONE MONTH AND NONE IN THE NEXT MONTH.

IF UNEARNED INCOME OTHER THAN CHILD SUPPORT FLUCTUATES, AVERAGE THE AMOUNT RECEIVED IN THE LAST 2 MONTHS TO DETERMINE THE MONTHLY AMOUNT.

EXCEPTION: IF UNEARNED INCOME IS VERIFIED THROUGH THE OFS-FA WEB SYSTEM CLEARANCE SUMMARY, USE INCOME RECEIVED IN THE LAST TWO MONTHS AVAILABLE FROM THE 'AS OF DATE' SHOWN ON THE 'VERIFICATION DETAILS' PANEL.

REFER TO [B-620-8 SNAP/FITAP](#) FOR FLUCTUATING CHILD SUPPORT.

DO NOT USE PERIODS WHEN INCOME WAS NOT RECEIVED OR VARIED GREATLY DUE TO UNUSUAL CIRCUMSTANCES.

IF ALL ATTEMPTS TO VERIFY INCOME ARE UNSUCCESSFUL BECAUSE THE PAYOR FAILS OR REFUSES TO GIVE INFORMATION AND NO OTHER INCOME VERIFICATION CAN BE FOUND, DETERMINE WITH THE CLIENT AN AMOUNT TO USE IN THE BUDGET BASED ON THE BEST AVAILABLE INFORMATION.

B-662-FITAP - PO CONVERTING INCOME TO MONTHLY AMOUNTS

WHEN DETERMINING ELIGIBILITY AND BENEFITS, USE THE APPROPRIATE CONVERSION FACTORS TO DETERMINE THE MONTHLY AMOUNT. EXCEPT WHEN LESS THAN A FULL MONTH'S INCOME WAS RECEIVED BECAUSE:

- THE INCOME TERMINATES DURING THE MONTH, OR
- THE INCOME BEGINS DURING THE MONTH, OR

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- THE INCOME IS INTERRUPTED DURING THE MONTH.

IN THESE INSTANCES, USE ACTUAL INCOME OR THE BEST ESTIMATE OF ANTICIPATED ACTUAL INCOME.

B-663-FITAP - PO BUDGETING EXPENSES

TO DETERMINE ELIGIBILITY AND BENEFITS CONSIDER ONLY HOUSEHOLD EXPENSES THAT ARE EXPECTED DURING THE MONTH.

II. PROCEDURES

B-661-FITAP - PR HOW TO DETERMINE ELIGIBILITY AND BENEFITS

ENTER COUNTABLE INCOME ON LAMI.

B-661-1-FITAP - PR Determining Earned Income

* IF THE HOUSEHOLD PROVIDES VERIFICATION OF WAGES FROM AT LEAST TWO PAY PERIODS WHICH ARE REPRESENTATIVE OF INCOME FOR THE CURRENT CALENDAR MONTH AND PRIOR CALENDAR MONTH WHEN THE APPLICATION, REDETERMINATION, OR SIMPLIFIED REPORT IS RECEIVED, OR THE CHANGE IS REPORTED, NO ADDITIONAL WAGE VERIFICATION MUST BE REQUESTED, UNLESS THE VERIFICATION RECEIVED IS QUESTIONABLE.

IF VERIFICATION OF EARNINGS FROM AT LEAST TWO REPRESENTATIVE PAY PERIODS WITHIN THE CURRENT CALENDAR MONTH AND THE PRIOR CALENDAR MONTH HAVE NOT BEEN PROVIDED, REQUEST VERIFICATION OF ALL WAGES RECEIVED FROM THE CURRENT CALENDAR MONTH AND THE PRIOR CALENDAR MONTH. THE DATE THE VERIFICATION IS REQUESTED IS THE DETERMINING FACTOR ON WHICH MONTHS TO REQUEST THE VERIFICATION. **

EXAMPLE: CLIENT APPLIES ON JULY 7 AND DOES NOT PROVIDE WAGE VERIFICATION. CLIENT IS INTERVIEWED ON JULY 20; THEREFORE WAGES RECEIVED FROM JUNE 1 - JULY 20 SHOULD BE REQUESTED. JUNE IS THE PRIOR CALENDAR MONTH AND JULY IS THE CURRENT CALENDAR MONTH. IF CLIENT PROVIDES AT LEAST TWO CHECK STUBS THAT ARE REPRESENTATIVE BETWEEN JUNE 1 – JULY 20, USE THOSE PAY PERIODS TO ESTIMATE EARNINGS.

EXAMPLE: CLIENT SUBMITS REDETERMINATION FORM ON JUNE 20 FOR A JULY REDETERMINATION. CLIENT IS INTERVIEWED ON JUNE 21. WAGES FROM MAY 1 - JUNE 21

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SHOULD BE REQUESTED. THE CLIENT PROVIDED CHECK STUBS DATED MAY 26, JUNE 16, AND JULY 7 THAT ARE REPRESENTATIVE. SINCE THE CLIENT HAS PROVIDED MORE CURRENT EARNINGS, USE PAY PERIODS OF JUNE 16 AND JULY 7.

YEAR-TO-DATE (YTD) INFORMATION CAN BE USED TO CALCULATE THE AMOUNT OF A MISSING PAY PERIOD TO HELP DETERMINE IF CHECK STUBS PROVIDED ARE REPRESENTATIVE OF EARNINGS. TO DETERMINE THE GROSS AMOUNT OF MISSING PAYCHECKS, EACH CALCULATION MUST BE DONE SEPARATELY.

EXAMPLE: THE CLIENT APPLIES ON 3/1. SHE IS PAID WEEKLY ON FRIDAYS. SHE HAS CHECK STUBS FROM 2/25 AND 2/11. SHE IS MISSING THE CHECK STUB FROM 2/18.

TO DETERMINE THE GROSS AMOUNT OF THE MISSING PAYCHECK, SUBTRACT THE YEAR-TO-DATE GROSS INCOME OF THE CHECK FROM 2/11 FROM THE YEAR-TO-DATE GROSS INCOME OF THE CHECK FROM 2/25. SUBTRACT THE GROSS INCOME FROM THE CHECK DATED 2/25 FROM THIS AMOUNT. THE DIFFERENCE WILL BE THE GROSS INCOME AMOUNT OF THE MISSING CHECK FROM 2/18. ENSURE THAT THE RATE OF PAY IS THE SAME ON THE CHECKS PROVIDED TO DETERMINE IF THE RATE OF PAY CHANGED. ENSURE THAT THE AMOUNT OF THE MISSING CHECK IS INDICATIVE OF A NORMAL PAY PERIOD AS COMPARED TO THE GROSS INCOME OF THE OTHER CHECKS. DOCUMENT THE CASE RECORD THOROUGHLY.

IF THE CLIENT HAS A NEW SOURCE OF EARNED INCOME AND HAS NOT BEEN EMPLOYED AT LEAST TWO FULL PAY PERIODS OR VERIFICATION OF INCOME FROM AT LEAST TWO PAY PERIODS IS PROVIDED BUT THERE ARE NOT AT LEAST TWO PAY PERIODS THAT ARE REPRESENTATIVE OF EARNINGS:

- CONTACT THE EMPLOYER TO DETERMINE THE START DATE AND OBTAIN SUFFICIENT INFORMATION TO ESTIMATE FUTURE EARNINGS (e.g., NUMBER OF HOURS EXPECTED TO WORK, HOURLY WAGE, ETC.), AND
- DOCUMENT THE CASE RECORD TO SHOW BASIS OF ESTIMATE.

IF A CHANGE IN THE HOURLY RATE HAS OCCURRED or is anticipated:

- CONTACT THE EMPLOYER OR USE CHECK STUBS TO VERIFY NEW HOURLY RATE,
- AVERAGE HOURS WORKED FOR AT LEAST TWO PAY PERIODS, AND
- MULTIPLY HOURS WORKED BY NEW HOURLY RATE TO ESTIMATE INCOME.

IF A CHANGE IN THE NUMBER OF HOURS WORKED HAS OCCURRED or is anticipated:

- CONTACT THE EMPLOYER TO VERIFY NEW NUMBER OF HOURS TO BE WORKED, AND

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- MULTIPLY NEW NUMBER OF HOURS TO BE WORKED BY HOURLY WAGE.

A CHANGE FOR PURPOSES OF THIS SECTION DOES NOT INCLUDE NORMAL FLUCTUATIONS IN THE NUMBER OF HOURS WORKED, AMOUNT PAID OR SHORT TERM TEMPORARY CHANGES SUCH AS COVERING FOR ANOTHER EMPLOYEE WHO WAS ILL. IT DOES INCLUDE CHANGES IN HOURLY WAGE, CHANGING FROM PART-TIME TO FULL-TIME OR VICE-VERSA, ETC.

DO NOT USE PAY PERIODS WHEN, DUE TO UNUSUAL CIRCUMSTANCES, INCOME WAS NOT RECEIVED OR VARIED GREATLY AND DOES NOT APPEAR TO BE REPRESENTATIVE OF EARNINGS. IF AN ATYPICAL CHECK WAS RECEIVED AND THE CIRCUMSTANCES ARE NOT EXPECTED TO RECUR, EXCLUDE THE CHECK AND DOCUMENT THE RECORD TO REFLECT THE BASIS OF THE DECISION. FOR EXAMPLE, DO NOT INCLUDE A PAY PERIOD IN WHICH THE CLIENT DID NOT WORK DUE TO DEATH IN THE FAMILY OR A PAY PERIOD IN WHICH THE CLIENT WORKED OVERTIME WHICH IS NOT EXPECTED TO RECUR.

EXAMPLE: DURING THE INTERVIEW, THE CLIENT STATES THAT SHE MAKES AN AVERAGE OF \$250 A WEEK. THE CLIENT PROVIDES TWO CHECK STUBS, ONE THAT IS FOR \$150 AND ONE FOR \$200. THE CLIENT MUST BE CONTACTED TO DISCUSS THIS DISCREPANCY TO MAKE A DETERMINATION IF THE CHECK STUBS PROVIDED ARE REPRESENTATIVE OF HER EARNINGS. IF THE CHECK STUBS ARE NOT REPRESENTATIVE OF HER EARNINGS, ADDITIONAL VERIFICATION MUST BE OBTAINED. THE INTERVIEW WIZARD MUST BE DOCUMENTED TO INDICATE WHICH CHECKS ARE REPRESENTATIVE OF EARNINGS. IF THE WIZARD IS UNAVAILABLE, DOCUMENT ON THE [OFS 3](#).

EXAMPLE: DURING THE INTERVIEW, THE CLIENT STATES THAT SHE MAKES AN AVERAGE OF \$250 A WEEK. THE CLIENT PROVIDES TWO CHECK STUBS, ONE THAT IS FOR \$250 AND ONE FOR \$230. THE WORKER DETERMINES THAT THESE CHECK STUBS ARE REPRESENTATIVE OF THE CLIENT'S EARNINGS. THE INTERVIEW WIZARD MUST BE DOCUMENTED TO INDICATE WHICH CHECKS ARE REPRESENTATIVE OF EARNINGS. IF THE WIZARD IS UNAVAILABLE, DOCUMENT ON THE [OFS 3](#).

PAY PERIODS IN WHICH NO INCOME WAS RECEIVED SHOULD BE USED IN THE ESTIMATE IF THESE ARE REGULAR OCCURRENCES IN EMPLOYMENT.

THE WORKER MUST DETERMINE IF INCOME FOR ALL PAY PERIODS IS REPRESENTATIVE OF EARNINGS. THIS MUST BE DOCUMENTED FOR EACH PAY PERIOD PROVIDED THAT APPEARS NOT TO BE REPRESENTATIVE. PAST HISTORY (WITH THE SAME EMPLOYER), WORKER JUDGMENT, OR A DISCUSSION WITH THE CLIENT OR EMPLOYER MAY BE USED TO DETERMINE IF PAY PERIODS ARE REPRESENTATIVE.

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IF, DUE TO UNIQUE CIRCUMSTANCES SUCH AS PAY PERIODS OF LESS THAN WEEKLY, NONE OF THE METHODS DESCRIBED ABOVE GIVE THE MOST ACCURATE ESTIMATE OF MONTHLY EARNINGS:

- USE THE METHOD WHICH GIVES THE MOST ACCURATE ESTIMATE OF EARNINGS, AND
- DOCUMENT THE CASE RECORD TO CLEARLY SHOW THE BASIS OF THE ESTIMATE AND THE REASON THE METHOD CHOSEN MOST ACCURATELY ESTIMATES ANTICIPATED EARNINGS.

IF AN EMPLOYEE ASKS THE EMPLOYER TO HOLD HIS WAGES, COUNT THIS MONEY AS INCOME IN THE MONTH THE HOUSEHOLD WOULD OTHERWISE HAVE BEEN PAID. IF, HOWEVER, AN EMPLOYER HOLDS WAGES AS A GENERAL PRACTICE, DO NOT COUNT THIS MONEY AS INCOME UNLESS THE HOUSEHOLD EXPECTS TO ASK FOR AND RECEIVE AN ADVANCE OR THE HOUSEHOLD EXPECTS TO RECEIVE INCOME FROM PREVIOUSLY HELD WAGES. ADVANCES ON INCOME ARE A LOAN IN THE MONTH OF RECEIPT AND INCOME WHEN HELD OUT OF WAGES FOR REPAYMENT.

IF ALL ATTEMPTS TO VERIFY INCOME ARE UNSUCCESSFUL BECAUSE THE PAYOR FAILS OR REFUSES TO GIVE INFORMATION AND NO OTHER INCOME VERIFICATION CAN BE FOUND, DETERMINE WITH THE CLIENT AN AMOUNT TO USE IN THE BUDGET BASED ON THE BEST AVAILABLE INFORMATION.

B-662-FITAP - PR HOW TO CONVERT INCOME TO MONTHLY AMOUNTS

WHEN DETERMINING ELIGIBILITY AND BENEFITS, USE THE APPROPRIATE CONVERSION FACTOR TO DETERMINE THE MONTHLY AMOUNT EXCEPT WHEN LESS THAN A FULL MONTH'S INCOME WAS RECEIVED BECAUSE:

- THE INCOME TERMINATES DURING THE MONTH, OR
- THE INCOME BEGINS DURING THE MONTH, OR
- THE INCOME IS INTERRUPTED DURING THE MONTH.

IN THESE INSTANCES, USE ACTUAL INCOME OR THE BEST ESTIMATE OF ANTICIPATED ACTUAL INCOME.

INCOME RECEIVED MONTHLY OR SEMI-MONTHLY MUST BE COUNTED IN THE MONTH IT IS INTENDED TO COVER RATHER THAN THE MONTH IN WHICH IT IS RECEIVED WHEN AN EXTRA CHECK IS RECEIVED IN ONE MONTH BECAUSE OF CHANGES IN PAY DATES FOR REASONS SUCH AS WEEKENDS OR HOLIDAYS.

INCOME IS CONVERTED TO MONTHLY AMOUNTS BY USING THE FOLLOWING CONVERSION FACTORS:

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- DIVIDE YEARLY INCOME BY 12, OR
- MULTIPLY WEEKLY INCOME BY 4.333, OR
- ADD AMOUNTS RECEIVED TWICE A MONTH, OR
- MULTIPLY AMOUNTS RECEIVED EVERY OTHER WEEK BY 2.167.

B-663-FITAP - PR HOW TO BUDGET EXPENSES

Determine and verify monthly dependent care according to procedures in [B-651-2 FITAP](#).

III. FORMS AND INSTRUCTIONS

[OFS 3 Form/Instructions](#) Earned Income Budgeting Sheet

IV. REFERENCES

[LAC 67:III.1229](#)